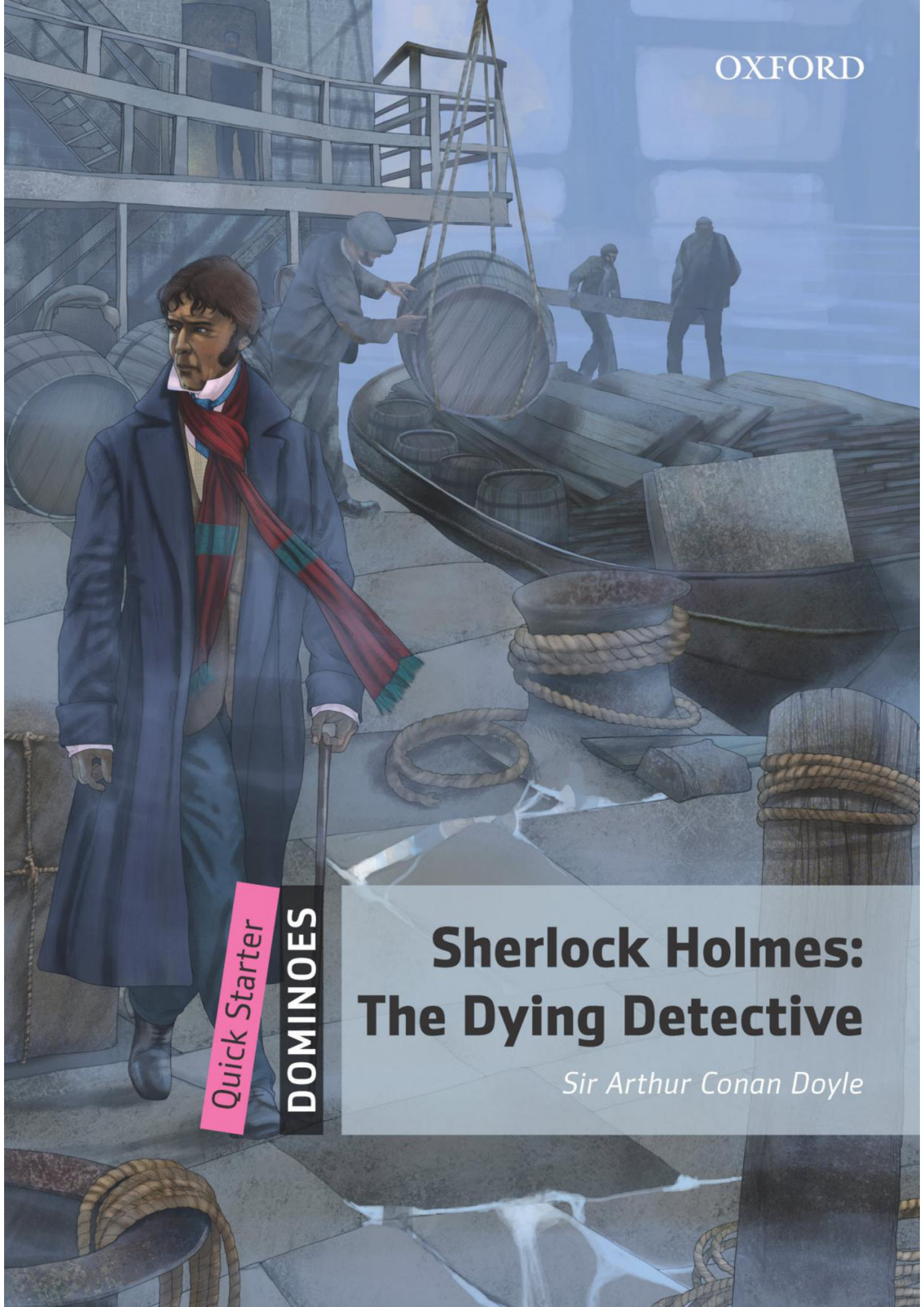


An illustration of Sherlock Holmes in a dark blue coat and red scarf, holding a cane, standing on a ship's deck. In the background, two men are loading wooden barrels onto a small boat using a crane. The scene is set on a ship with a wooden railing and various nautical equipment like ropes and a bollard.

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Quick Starter

DOMINOES

Sherlock Holmes: The Dying Detective

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle

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Sherlock Holmes: The Dying Detective

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle



Founder Editors: Bill Bowler and Sue Parminter

Text adaptation by Lesley Thompson

Illustrated by Giorgio Bacchin

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle (1859–1930), born in Edinburgh, Scotland, is best known as the creator of Sherlock Holmes. He started writing after working as a doctor, and soon became one of the world's best-known authors. The Sherlock Holmes stories *The Blue Diamond*, *The Emerald Crown*, *The Norwood Mystery*, *The Sign of Four*, *The Top-Secret Plans*, and *The Speckled Band* are also available as Dominoes.

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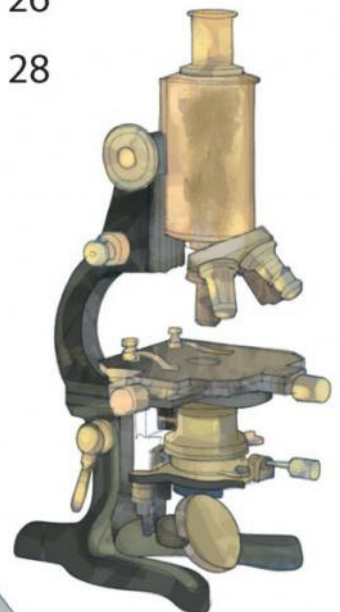
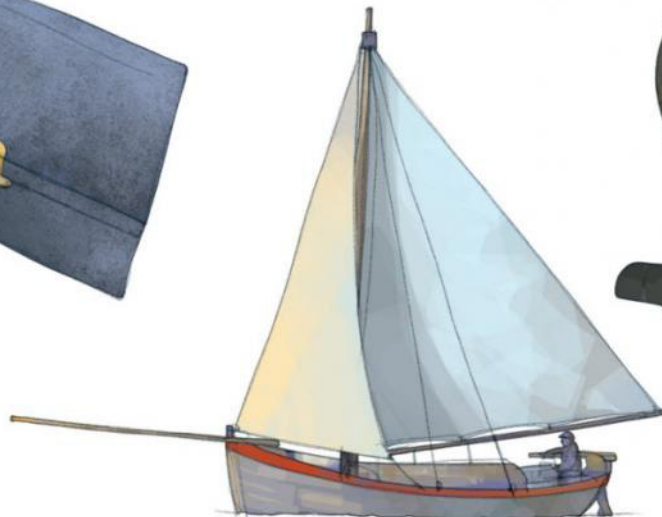
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Story Characters



Sherlock Holmes



Doctor Watson

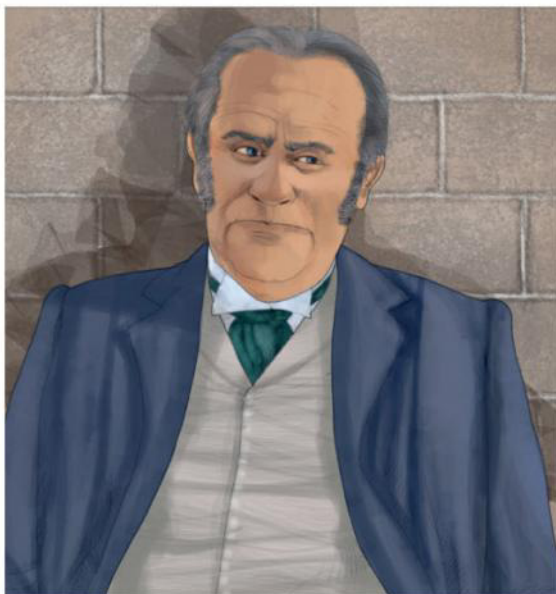
Story Characters



Mrs Hudson



Inspector Morton



Mr Culverton Smith



Victor Savage

1. Holmes is ill



It is 1890 in London. At 221b Baker Street, Mrs Hudson, Sherlock Holmes's **servant**, is **sad**. Things are very bad. Holmes is dying!

'Three days now, and he is worse!' she thinks.

Mrs Hudson likes Holmes very much but she is also a little afraid of him. He is different. He has **strange** visitors and they come at all hours of the day and night. His rooms have many strange things in them. But he is very nice to Mrs Hudson. She **respects** him and she does not want to lose him.

'I must visit **Dr** Watson,' she thinks. 'He can help.'

At this time, Dr Watson is living in a different street in London. Mrs Hudson goes quickly to his rooms.

'Dr Watson!' she cries when the doctor opens the door to her. 'Please come with me. It's Mr Holmes. He's dying!'

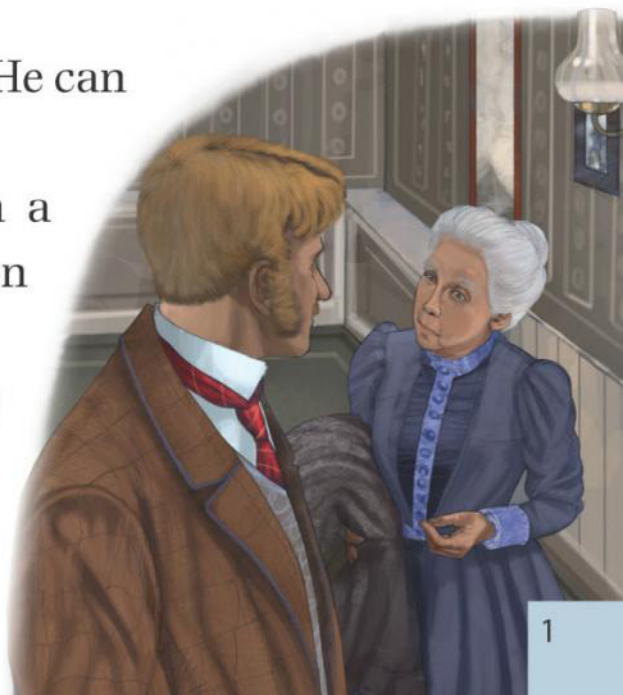
servant a person who works for someone rich

sad not happy

strange not usual

respect to think that someone is good

Dr, doctor this person helps people when they are ill



ill, illness being
not well

cab a car pulled
by a horse

river a long line
of water

‘What?’ Watson cries. ‘I know nothing about this!’

‘He doesn’t want a doctor but you must come, sir. After three days, he’s very, very **ill**. He’s saying strange things. I’m afraid for him. You must be quick!’

Watson gets his coat and bag and they leave the house. In the **cab**, he asks Mrs Hudson some more questions.

‘I can’t tell you much, sir. Lately, Mr Holmes is working in Rotherhithe, near the **river**. He comes home and he brings this **illness** with him. He’s much worse now. Can he live through this?’



2. Watson cannot help

detective a man or woman who finds criminals

fever a person with this is very hot and ill

voice you talk or sing with this

weak not strong

poor something you say when you feel sorry for someone

towards nearer

When they arrive at Baker Street on that dark, November day, Holmes is alive. But Watson is afraid for his friend. The **detective**'s face is yellow, and his eyes are red with **fever**. His hands move without stopping. When he speaks, his **voice** is **weak**.

'Well, Watson, bad days are here, I think.' He smiles weakly.

'My **poor** man!' cries Watson and he moves **towards** the bed.



‘Don’t come near me!’

‘But why? I only want to help.’

‘I know, but you can’t help me. My illness is from the Far East and it’s very **contagious**.’

‘I’m a doctor,’ says Watson quietly. ‘These things don’t matter to me.’

‘Don’t move, and I can talk to you. If not, you must leave the room now.’

contagious an illness which is easy to get



trust to think
someone is good

specialist
someone who
knows a lot about
something

lock to make a
door stay closed

shock very
surprised by
something bad

Holmes looks at Watson with fever in his eyes.

‘I can’t **trust** you with this, Watson. You know nothing of these strange illnesses. Do you know about Tapanuli fever, for example? Or the black Formosa fever? No, you don’t. You aren’t a **specialist**. I’m sorry to say this, but I must see a specialist.’

Watson is not happy at these words, but he also respects the detective.

‘Very well, Holmes. Dr Ainstree, the best specialist in these illnesses, is now in London. I’m going to him now.’

Watson walks towards the door. Suddenly, Holmes is out of bed. He goes quickly to the door and **locks** it. Then he goes very slowly back to bed. Watson looks at his friend in **shock**. What is the matter with Holmes?



3. Holmes is worse

Holmes cries excitedly, 'Stay here, Watson! I've got the **key**! What time is it? Four o'clock? At six o'clock you can go, but not before!'

Watson looks at his friend sadly.

'Holmes, this illness is doing strange things to your head. But I can wait until six.'

'Good! One more thing, Watson. Don't bring that man, Ainstree. Now, perhaps I can sleep a little.'

Watson waits, looking at the pictures and books in the room. On a table, he sees a little black and white **box**. 'That's interesting,' he thinks. He moves his hand towards it. Suddenly, a **terrible** cry comes from the bed.

'Stop, Watson! Don't move my things. I don't like it. Sit down, man! I need to sleep!'

key you use this to lock a door

box a square thing which you put things in

terrible very bad



At six o'clock, Holmes says, 'Let's have some **light**, Watson. But only a little! Put the box near me. Not with your hands! Use your **handkerchief**! That's right. Now, you can go to Mr Culverton Smith of 13 Lower **Burke** Street.'



'But who is this man, Holmes? I don't know the name.'

'He isn't a doctor. He has a **plantation** in **Sumatra** but he's visiting London. He knows this illness well because his workers often have it.

Things are not good between us. Smith's **nephew**, Victor Savage, is dead. There is something wrong about his terrible death. I don't trust Smith and he knows it. But only he can help me. There is one more thing. Don't come back with him. You must be here before him. This is very important, Watson.'

light this stops a place being dark

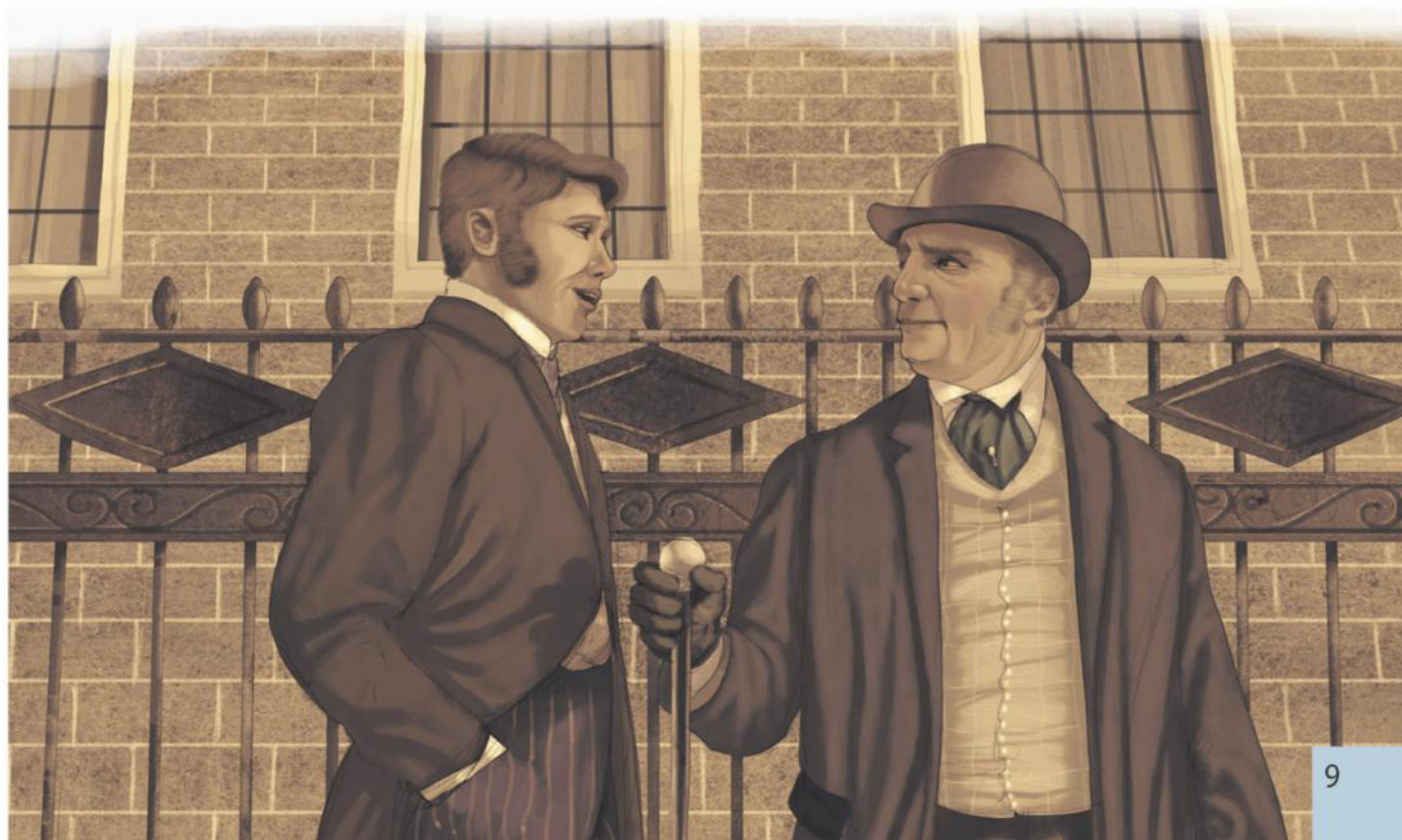
handkerchief a small square white cloth

Burke /bɜːrk/

plantation a big farm in a hot country

Sumatra /suˈmɑːtrə/

nephew your brother or sister's son



Inspector an important police officer

Scotland Yard the most important place for the police in London

Watson takes the key and he goes into the street. He sees **Inspector** Morton of **Scotland Yard**.

‘How is Mr Holmes, sir?’ Morton asks.

‘He’s very ill,’ Watson answers.

Morton smiles strangely. ‘I know something about it,’ he says.

Watson doesn’t understand, but he cannot wait. He gets into a cab and leaves.



4. The specialist

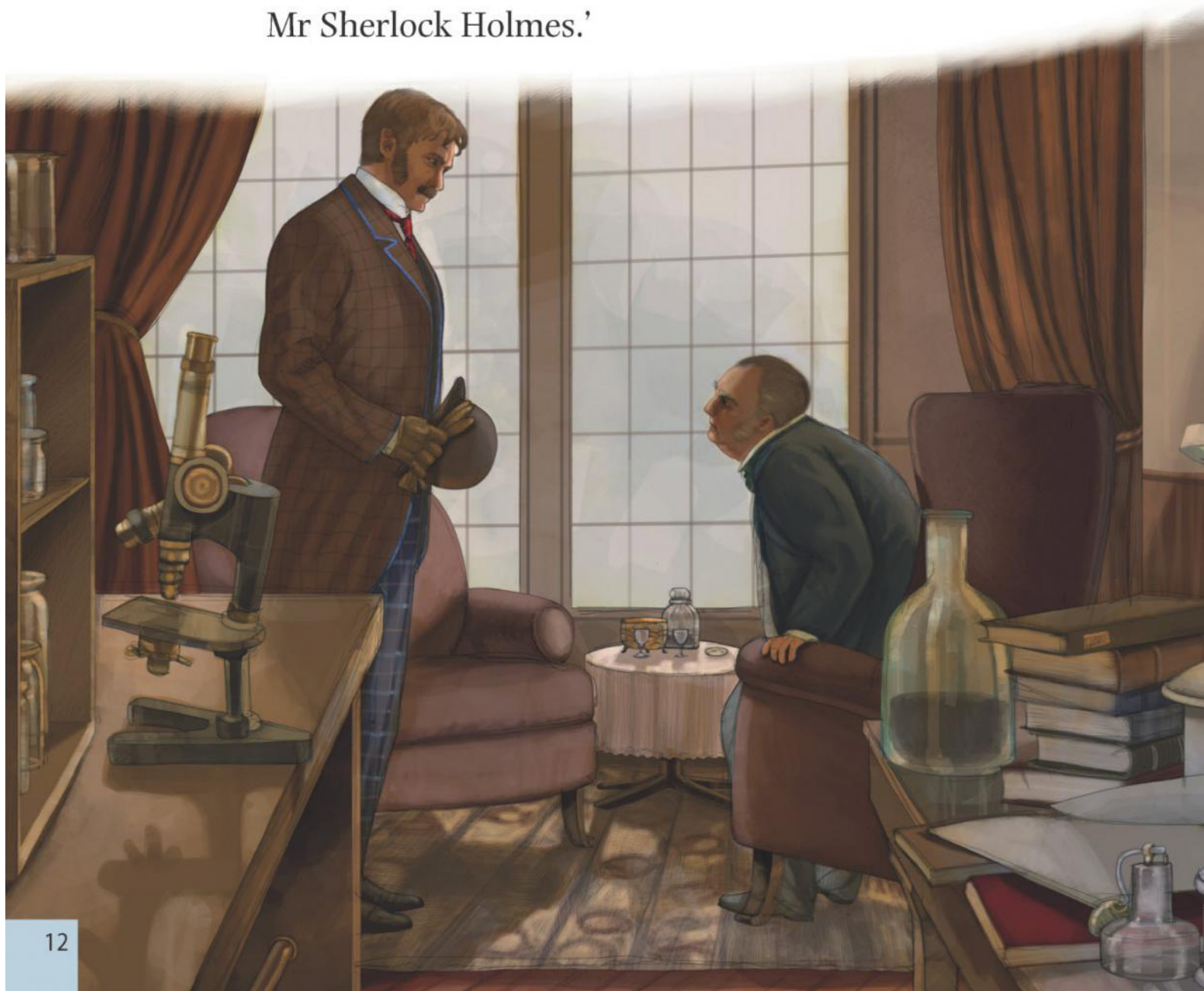
At 13 Lower Burke Street, a servant answers the door. Watson goes into the house. He can hear Culverton Smith's voice.

'Who is Watson? What does he want? I need to work. I cannot see him.'

Watson thinks of Holmes. Quickly he goes into the room. The man in the room stands up from his chair. Watson sees his dark, angry eyes.

'What's this?' the man cries.

'I'm sorry,' says Watson, 'but I can't wait. It's about Mr Sherlock Holmes.'



Culverton Smith's face changes. He watches Watson carefully.

'What about Holmes? How is he?'

'He's very ill.'

Watson sits down. Is that a smile on Smith's face?

'I'm sorry to hear this,' Smith says. 'I don't know Holmes well, but I respect him. We're not very different. He studies **criminals** and I study **microbes**.' He looks at the bottles on the table next to him and laughs.

criminal a bad person who the police are looking for

microbe a very little thing which can make you ill



‘Holmes needs you,’ Watson says.

‘Why? Is his illness from the Far East?’

‘Perhaps. His work lately is with people from there.’

‘Oh, I see,’ Smith smiles. ‘How many days is it now?’

‘About three.’

‘Is he thinking well?’

‘Not always.’

‘That is bad. I must go and help him.’

Watson remembers Holmes’s words. He says,
‘I can’t go with you. I need to make a visit.’

‘Very well,’ Smith says. ‘I can be there in half an hour.’





5. A killer at Baker Street

Watson runs into Holmes's room.

'Is he coming?' Holmes asks.

'Yes, he is.'

'Very good, Watson! Now you must **hide** behind the bed. Don't speak or move. Just listen very carefully.'

Watson hides behind the bed and waits. Soon, he hears Culverton Smith's voice.

'Can you hear me, Holmes?'

'Is that you, Mr Smith?' Holmes says weakly. 'Thank you for coming.'

Smith laughs. 'What's the matter with you, Holmes?'

'It's Victor's illness, I think,'

'Yes! My nephew! Four days ill and he's dead!' Smith laughs again.

'And you are the criminal, Smith.'

'Ah, but you can't **prove** it! And now you need me!'

'Give me water!' Holmes says weakly.

'All right, but only because I want to say something to you. Your illness is from men working near the river, your friend says. But that's wrong. You aren't very quick, are you Holmes?'

'I can't think. You must help me!'

'Think carefully. Think about a box arriving here last Wednesday.'

'A box... yes, I remember now. The **spring** in the box on my hand... the **blood**!'

hide to go where people can't see you

prove to show that something is true

spring a thin metal thing in a watch or clock

blood this is red; you can see it when you cut your hand





‘That’s right. And there are microbes of your illness on that spring. This box is the only **proof**, and I’m taking it with me! Now you know the **truth**. Now you can die!’

‘More light,’ says Holmes weakly. Smith moves and suddenly there is more light in the room. ‘What more can I do for you?’ Smith asks.

‘And more water, please,’ Holmes says. But what is happening? Holmes is speaking **normally**. His voice is not weak. Watson hears this and he nearly cries out. He can feel Culverton Smith’s shock.

proof a thing which shows that something is true

truth what is true

normally in a usual way

6. The truth



‘What is this? Aren’t you ill?’ Culverton Smith asks angrily.

‘After three days without food or drink I’m not very well. But I’m much better than you think,’ Holmes says in his normal voice. ‘Ah, a friend is coming, I think. The light is telling him to come.’

The door opens and Inspector Morton comes in.

‘This is your man, Inspector,’ Holmes says.

‘I **arrest** you for the **murder** of Victor Savage,’ Morton says to Smith.

arrest to take
(a criminal) to the
police station

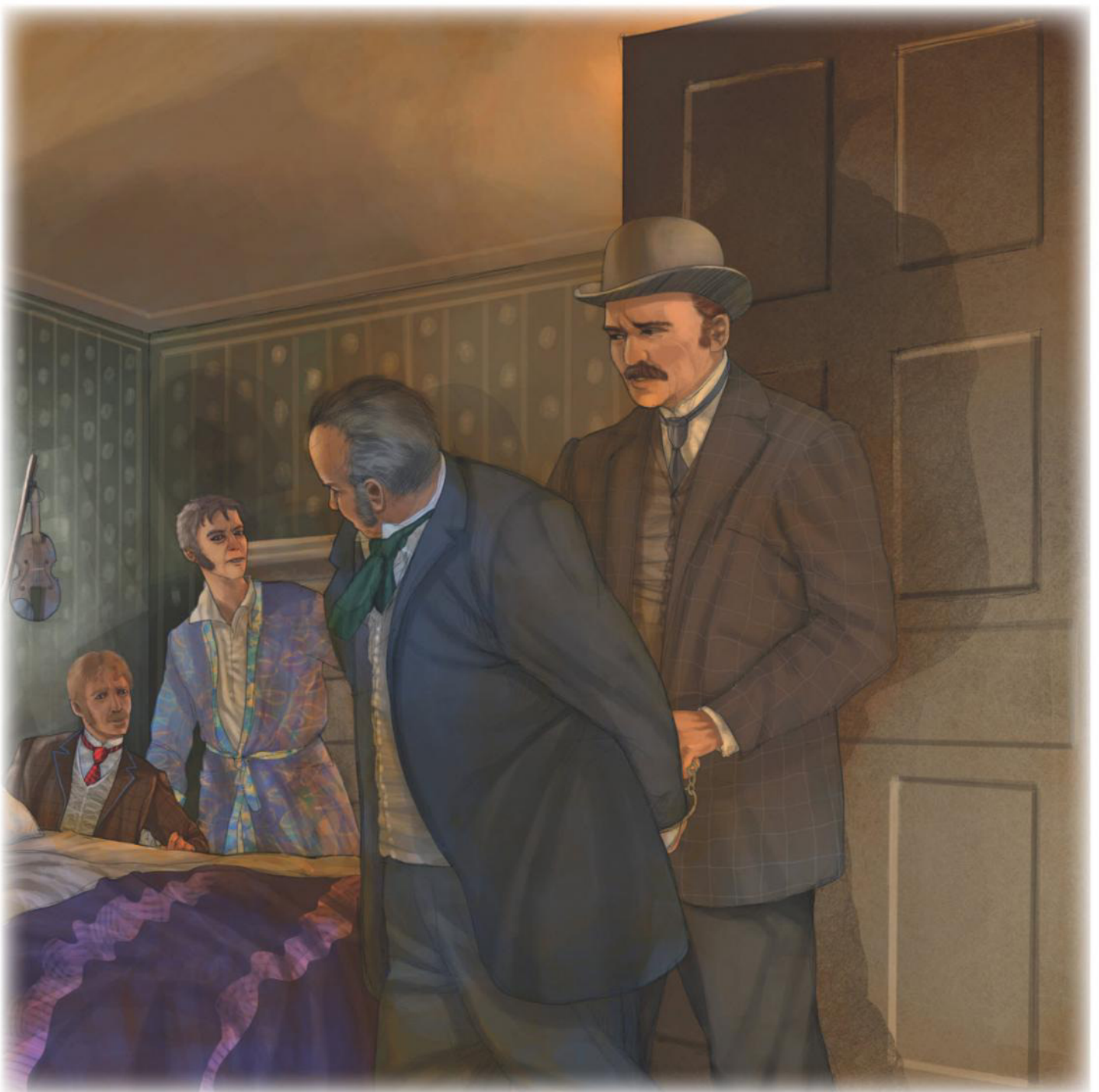
murder the
killing of someone

‘He wants my murder, too.’ Holmes laughs. ‘The proof is in the box in his coat. But don’t put your hand on it, Inspector’.

Smith cries, ‘You can’t prove anything, Holmes!’

‘Don’t forget my friend, Dr Watson,’ Holmes says. ‘He can tell an interesting story. Come out, Watson!’

Morton leaves with Culverton Smith. Holmes dresses and then he talks to Watson.



‘I’m a good **actor**, Watson. And no food or drink for three days is easy for me. This yellow face is only **make-up**. You can’t come near me and not see the truth – so my ‘illness’ is contagious. Bad light in the room helps with my **act**.

actor someone who works in films or the theatre

make-up colours that you can put on your face

act something which an actor does; something which is not true

Victor Savage’s murder is all about money. Money is more important than family to Culverton Smith. I get some strange things at this house. Happily, I always open them very carefully!

Now we must go to Scotland Yard. After that, I want to sit down with you and eat until midnight!’



Sherlock Holmes: The Dying Detective

'Come quickly, Dr Watson,' says Mrs Hudson.
'Sherlock Holmes is dying!'

Sherlock Holmes was trying to solve a murder.
But now he has a terrible illness, and he is not
his normal self. Can his friend Watson help him?
Can the strange Mr Culverton Smith help him?
Or will Sherlock Holmes die?

Text adaptation by Lesley Thompson
Illustrated by Giorgio Bacchin



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